

Hit to the head: what to do in the first minutes

She doesn't need to black out and the head doesn't need to be hit: the force can come from an impact elsewhere on the body. **If in doubt, she comes off.**

1 • Red flags: call an ambulance

If even one of these appears and no healthcare professional is present, call emergency services straight away:

- neck pain or tenderness
- double vision
- weakness, tingling or burning in arms or legs
- severe or increasing headache
- seizure or convulsion
- loss of consciousness
- deteriorating conscious state, growing confusion
- vomiting
- increasingly restless, agitated or combative

With neck pain, do not move her or remove a helmet unless you are trained to.

2 • Signs that mean she comes off now

- lying motionless, or slow to get up
- blank look, confusion, wrong answers
- poor balance, unsteady gait, uncoordinated movement
- can't remember the play or what happened before
- changes in behaviour

3 • The rule, no exceptions

- **She comes off and doesn't return today**, even if she says she's fine, even in a final.
- **She is not left alone** for the first 1-2 hours and goes home with an adult.
- **No alcohol** and no medicines unless a doctor says so.
- Symptoms can appear **hours or days later**: check again that evening and the next day.
- Return to play is cleared by **a healthcare professional**, not the coach.

The first 48 hours

Relative rest, not a dark room: daily activities and less screen time. Then a gradual return, school first and sport after, in 6 stages of at least 24 hours each.

22 vs 44

days to recover: removed at once vs kept playing (69 athletes aged 12-19, small sample)

60%

of the episodes athletes remembered were never reported to an adult (167 high-school athletes)

The official recognition tool is the Concussion in Sport Group's **CRT6**, also available in a validated Italian version (2025).